

Case 5: Grow Alone or Team Up?

Domain: Sales and Marketing | Decision Archetype: Market Expansion | Framework: PESTEL

Transcript excerpt — "The Founder's Chair" podcast, Episode 47

Host: So Pulse Broadband has been in 8 cities for three years now. What's next?

Founder (Raghav Iyer): Honestly, that's the question keeping me up. We could expand to 15 more cities on our own — we know how to lay fibre, we know the playbook. But something's changed in the last year that makes it more complicated.

Host: Like what?

Raghav: A few things. The government's pushed new rules — every new city rollout now needs additional right-of-way permissions that take 4-6 months longer than before. Inflation's made cable and equipment costs jump 18% this year alone. And two of the cities we want to enter already have a local player who's spent five years building relationships with apartment societies — that's not something we can just walk into.

Host: So build it yourself is looking expensive and slow.

Raghav: Right. Which is why we're seriously looking at partnering with regional ISPs instead of doing it all ourselves. They already have the local permissions, the local trust, the last-mile connections. We'd bring our brand, our tech backend, better customer app. But partnering means giving up control — and margin.

Host: What's stopping you from just deciding today?

Raghav: We don't know if these regulatory hurdles are temporary — election-year caution, maybe — or the new normal. If it's temporary, waiting six months and going alone might actually be smarter.

Exhibit 1 — What's Changed in the Operating Environment

Factor	Change	Impact on Pulse
Political/Regulatory	New right-of-way approval rules	+4-6 months per city if going solo
Economic	Equipment cost inflation	+18% cost this year
Social	Rising demand for home broadband (post-hybrid work)	Positive — more demand

Technological	Fibre-laying tech now faster per km	Positive — partially offsets delays
Legal	2 target cities have exclusive local cable body agreements	Local partner needed to access these

Exhibit 2 — Build vs Partner Snapshot

	Go Alone	Partner with Regional ISP
Time to launch in new cities	10-12 months	3-4 months
Control over brand/pricing	Full	Shared
Margin retained	100%	~60-65%

Discussion Questions

1. Should Pulse Broadband expand alone, partner with regional ISPs, or wait six months?
2. Which of the external factors above matters most to this decision?
3. If you were Raghav, would you make the same decision in every one of the 15 cities, or mix approaches city by city?